

Board 1

North Deals

None Vul

♠ 10 9 6 3
♥ 9 3
♦ K 5
♣ 10 9 8 4 2

♠ A J 4

♥ A K 7

♦ 10 7 4 2

♣ K J 3



♠ Q 7 5

♥ Q J 10 8 5 2

♦ A 3

♣ Q 5

♠ K 8 2

♥ 6 4

♦ Q J 9 8 6

♣ A 7 6

West	North	East	South
	1NT	2♥	3♦
Pass	3NT		
All Pass			
3NT by North			

Partner's 3♦ bid shows a 5-card suit and is forcing to game. While 5♦ is possibly the best contract your double ♥ stopper should sway you to 3NT instead. This is the old "9 tricks are easier than 11" principle.

North plays 3NT. As expected, East attacks in his ♥ suit.

Winner List: ♠ = 2 : ♥ = 2 : ♦ = 0 : ♣ = 2 :: Total = 6

Even if West holds both black Queens, (not likely), you can only finesse your way to 8 tricks. Since you need 9 tricks you must establish the ♦ suit.

If East holds both the ♦ A and ♦ K then you are going down, because they will win the race to establish ♥s before you can establish ♦s.

But when the ♦ A and ♦ K are in different hands you have a good chance for success; it depends on West having no ♥ at the time he takes his ♦ winner.

So you should hold up on the first ♥ trick and win the second. If East started with 6 ♥s then West will be out. So whether he wins his ♦ trick first or second he still won't be able to continue ♥s.

After your hold up West has no ♥s. If he takes the first ♦ trick he will have to lead another suit. You will still have a ♥ stopper for when East wins **HIS** ♦ trick.

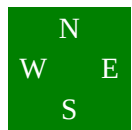
On the other hand, if East takes the first ♦ trick he can certainly drive out your last ♥ stopper. But then, when West takes **HIS** ♦ winner he will have no ♥.

Finally, if East had only a 5-card ♥ suit, good defense would beat you. But they have to be sure West wins the first ♦ trick, and they might slip up.

Board 3
East Deals
E-W Vul

♠ K 5
♥ J 7 5 3
♦ Q 6 2
♣ 8 5 4 2

♠ A 7 4
♥ K 10 4 2
♦ J 9 7 4
♣ Q J



♠ J 9 6
♥ A 8
♦ A K 10 5 3
♣ A K 6

♠ Q 10 8 3 2
♥ Q 9 6
♦ 8
♣ 10 9 7 3

West	North	East	South
3♣	Pass	2NT	Pass
3NT		3♦	Pass
All Pass			

3NT by East
Winner List: ♠ = 1 : ♥ = 1 : ♦ = 3 : ♣ = 2 :: Total = 7

Partner's 2NT opening shows 20-21 points so you know you want to be in game. To find out which game you bid a Stayman 3♣. Partner replies 3♦.

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You don't have a 4-4 ♥ fit, so you bid 3NT.

The contract would be 3NT played by West.

East plays 3NT. South leads the ♠3. Your first problem is which ♠ to play from dummy. That is an easy problem. If you play the ♠K you might lose the first five or six tricks. If you play low you guarantee a ♠ stopper. North plays the ♠A and returns the ♠7 to dummy's ♠K. South plays the ♠2 on this trick.

You need 2 more winners, and you need to get them before you lose the lead because it appears that South can cash 3 more ♠ tricks.

That means you need all 5 ♦ tricks. The good news is that the 5 missing ♦s will split 3-2 about two-thirds of the time. The bad news is that they will be 4-1 about one-third of the time. Can you protect yourself against a 4-1 break?

Maybe and maybe not. If South has ♦ J x x x there won't be anything you can do about it. But if North has this holding then you can succeed if you play your cards right.

Did you like that "play your cards right" quip? First play a ♦ to your ♦K; both defenders follow. Next play a ♦ to dummy's ♦Q. South discards a ♣. You are conveniently in dummy so you play dummy's last ♦ and North's ♦ J 9 are caught in a pincer movement by your ♦ A 10 5.

It was important to play the ♦s exactly as described because dummy had only one entry left, the ♦Q.

Suppose your first ♦ play had been dummy's ♦Q. You could make your contract if you play a small ♦ and finesse the ♦10. But at that point you wouldn't know whether the ♦s were splitting evenly or not. You'd be risking defeat on a hand where everybody who played for the 3-2 split was making the contract.

By taking the **SECOND** ♦ trick with dummy's ♦Q the 4-1 split is exposed at the right time.